

Sahaptian Phonetic Pronunciation Guide

Adapted from the “Pronunciation Key” by Weyétmascañmay (Jennifer Karson Engum) and Sisaawipan (Roberta L. Conner) published in [Cáw Pawá Láakni They Are Not Forgotten: Sahaptian Place Names Atlas of the Cayuse, Umatilla, and Walla Walla](#) (2015).

It is important to note that a single standardized system of spelling or writing was not developed for the Umatilla, Walla Walla, Cayuse Nez Perce, and other Sahaptian languages and dialects relatively recently. The system that has been adopted by the CTUIR Language program is based on the Americanist alphabet system and matches one symbol to one sound. The following alphabet using Americanist symbols is intended to provide consistency and clarity with comparative examples of sounds.

ʔ the glottal stop; as in “uh-oh” (used in Cayuse Nez Perce words before the initial vowel)	ɨ High central unrounded vowel (barred i) – midway between i and u; never lengthened	qʷ ejective or hard qʷ
a as in father; as in bother (for Cayuse Nez Perce)	k as in Korea, key, kachina	s as in severe, sonic, hiss
aa same as a above, but drawn out longer	k̥ ejective or hard k	š as in short, sash, shimmer
aw as in south	kʷ as in quick	t as in tar, tooth, tumble
ay as in aisle, slide, eye	k̥ʷ ejective or “hard” kʷ	t̥ ejective or hard t
c as in mats, starts, tsar, tsunami	l as in land, laughter, live	λ voiceless lateral affricative (barred lambda), as if saying “tl” while blowing air out
č ejective or hard c (with a popping sound)	ɭ glottalized l (with creaky voice)	λ̥ ejective or hard λ
č̥ ejective or hard č̥	ɬ Voiceless lateral fricative (barred l), like a lateral lisp	u as in boot, soon, moon
e as in apple, trap, bad	m as in man, matter, mom	uu same as u but drawn out longer
ee same as e above, but drawn out longer	m̥ glottalized m (with creaky voice)	uy as in phooey, chop suey
ew as in cat, gliding to the w of cow	n as in noon, north, ant	w as in wait, wind, wood
ey as in cat, gliding to an ee sound	n̥ glottalized n (with creaky voice)	w̥ glottalized w (with creaky voice)
h as in happy, hunter, howl	o as in pole, stone, rote	x as in the German ich
i as in weed, seed, esteem	oo same as o, but drawn out longer	x̥ as in the German ach
ii same as i but lengthened	oy as in toy	xʷ labialized x; no known equivalent
iw as in few	p as in pipe, pond, pepper	x̥ʷ labialized xʷ; no known equivalent
	p̥ ejective or hard p	y as in yield, yam, yard
	q farther back in the throat than k; as in Iraq	y̥ glottalized y (with creaky voice)
	qʷ as in quick but farther back in throat	